



designed to jump forward; our bodies are built to jump vertically, not horizontally. If you try to leap over something, you often feel like you're going to fall forward. That's a safety mechanism. So to jump really far, you have to override that instinct, and that's something a lot of people don't yet understand.

Right now, there are only a few people alive who have truly mastered that: Mike Powell, myself, Larry Myricks, and a few others. I coach college kids now, and some of them compete around the world. But even then, I don't always see the desire to figure it out, because they're still winning.

Why do you think that is?

We live in a society that no longer rewards or even values the excellence of performance. We're too focused on the prize. That's what social media has done to us; it doesn't matter what you actually achieve. If you have enough likes, enough followers, and if you're

famous, then you've "won". It's not about excellence anymore.

You won a whole lot of medals, too! What motivated you then? You usually get motivated if you don't have something, after all.

It depends on what you want to achieve. I wanted to jump 8.90m — to match Bob Beamon. So, I kept jumping, trying to reach that mark. I was always motivated because I only came close once. That goal stayed with me.

In the sprints, I wanted to run faster, to break the world record. When I ran 9.93 for the world record, the next goal became 9.8. I always had a goal, and it wasn't about winning or being number one. It was about the performance, about achieving what I knew I was capable of.

The big thing is that I always jumped and ran for time and distance, not for place. What disappoints me about today's jumpers is that many aren't trying to

Rare defeat: Andreas Berger celebrates after edging past Carl Lewis by one hundredth of a second to win the 100m on the opening day of the Nehru Centenary International Athletic Meet in New Delhi on September 19, 1989.

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jump farther. They're content with mediocrity.

And I wish they weren't, because they have the talent. They work hard; they do everything right. But there isn't a single jumper in the world saying, 'I want to break Carl Lewis's record. I want to break Mike Powell's record.' That's my frustration. They're great athletes and great kids, but when I was 17, I said, 'I want to break Bob Beamon's world record'. It took me until I was 30 to do it, but that was my goal from the start.

Right now, I don't see anyone interested in breaking our records — they're satisfied with winning medals. It's not a lack of ability; it's cultural.